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From the editor-in-chief

Many of you will wonder why INDIA TODAY has focused so extensively on Indian education over the last few months. From the country's best colleges to the pitfalls in our education system and now, highlighting institutions and individuals who give Indian education a good name. Our reasons for doing so are simple: at the start of the academic year we are reminded yet again that education, or rather quality education, matters. It is central to a country's economic growth and social development. India's ambitions of becoming a leading global player will amount to nothing if its education system cannot produce the human resources needed to arrive at the high table of nations.

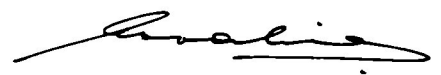
There is much that is wrong with our education—only 50 per cent of those who get into primary schools complete five years there, we confer only 18,000 Ph.D degrees per year as against the required number of 45,000 and only 11 per cent of those who enroll in our schools end up going to college. In the West, academics are acknowledged as the cream of a society's intelligentsia but our teachers work in trying conditions at very little pay with unsatisfactory research facilities.

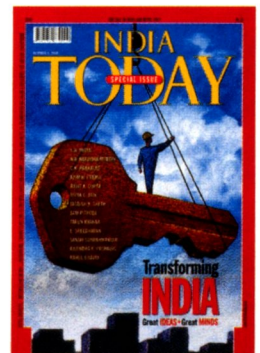
But there is plenty that is right too. Our numbers work to our advantage because we have more higher education students than any other country, outside the US and China. Our students pay far less for elite education: an Indian university charges \$10,000 for a business management course whereas a similar course in the US would cost close to \$80,000. The other piece of good news is that there are institutions and some very remarkable individuals who have bucked the system, beaten bureaucratic hurdles and overcome systemic ennui to make a vital difference to the societies around them.

For example, a government initiative in Chennai called Activity Based Learning started by an IAS officer did away with textbooks and is now being adopted by private schools. Then there's a two-man initiative which now produces one of every three Indian-born software engineers. And there's a dancer-cum-physicist whose determination to popularise science education has led to an overhaul of primary school textbooks.

The special issue this week, put together by Executive Editor Kaveree Bamzai, highlights the best in our education system, what we like to think are islands of hope in what is sadly a sea of mediocrity. We also picked the brains of some of India's finest academics for ideas on how to fix all that is broken. Their responses were insightful and varied: Yash Pal, former chairman of the UGC, explains why some colleges need to grow up and become universities; eminent scientist Roddam Narasimha brings our attention to an alarming statistic, that India registers 700 Ph.Ds in engineering and technology every year compared to China which registered close to 9,000. IIM Professor Anil Gupta reminds us that significant change will only be possible if India celebrates goodness and quality, particularly in its teachers.

We have also identified some of India's finest teachers, and we think of this special issue as our tribute to them, others like them and some of the great institutions they have built. May their tribe increase.


(Aroon Purie)



OUR OCTOBER 2008
SPIRIT OF INDIA COVER